It Is Written

Jesus faced temptation as we do and overcame it by trusting and obeying God's word, and he helps us to do the same.

Main passage	Matthew 4:1-11 (KJV)
Topic	Temptation
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Temptation comes at our weak points	7 min
Teaching point 2: Answer temptation with God's word	7 min
Teaching point 3: Worship God alone, and resist	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "When are you most easily tempted? When you are tired? Hungry? Lonely? Stressed?" Many people know the saying about not making decisions when you are hungry, angry, lonely or tired. Today we see Jesus tempted when he was hungry and alone, and we learn how he stood firm.

Scripture (3 min)

Matthew 4:1-11

[1] Then was Jesus led up of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted of the devil. [2] And when he had fasted forty days and forty nights, he was afterward an hungred. [3] And when the tempter came to him, he said, If thou be the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread. [4] But he answered and said, It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God. [5] Then the devil taketh him up into the holy city, and setteth him on a pinnacle of the temple, [6] And saith unto

him, If thou be the Son of God, cast thyself down: for it is written, He shall give his angels charge concerning thee: and in their hands they shall bear thee up, lest at any time thou dash thy foot against a stone. [7] Jesus said unto him, It is written again, Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God. [8] Again, the devil taketh him up into an exceeding high mountain, and sheweth him all the kingdoms of the world, and the glory of them; [9] And saith unto him, All these things will I give thee, if thou wilt fall down and worship me. [10] Then saith Jesus unto him, Get thee hence, Satan: for it is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve. [11] Then the devil leaveth him, and, behold, angels came and ministered unto him.

Read the passage aloud. Ask the class to count how many times Jesus says "It is written."

Background (5 min)

This event comes right after Jesus' baptism, when the Father's voice declared, "This is my beloved Son" (3:17). Immediately the Spirit led him into the wilderness, where he fasted forty days. The number recalls Israel's forty years in the wilderness. Where Israel often failed, Jesus, the true Son, stood firm. All three of his answers come from Deuteronomy 6-8, Moses' teaching to Israel about its wilderness years.

Matthew Henry calls this a "famous duel" between the Son of God and the serpent. Hebrews 4:15 tells us that Jesus "was in all points tempted like as we are, yet without sin."

Teaching point 1: Temptation comes at our weak points (7 min)

The devil came when Jesus was hungry and alone. He began with a doubt, "If thou be the Son of God," and a reasonable-sounding suggestion. Temptation rarely looks evil at first. It usually offers a shortcut to something good, by a path God has not given. Being tempted is not itself sin; Jesus was tempted and never sinned.

Supporting verses

Matthew 4:1-3: Then was Jesus led up of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted of the devil. And when he had fasted forty days and forty nights, he was afterward an hungred. And when the tempter came to him, he said, If thou be the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread.

Hebrews 4:15: For we have not an high priest which cannot be touched with the feeling of our infirmities; but was in all points tempted like as we are, yet without sin.

James 1:13-15: Let no man say when he is tempted, I am tempted of God: for God cannot be tempted with evil, neither tempteth he any man: But every man is tempted, when he is drawn away of his own lust, and enticed. Then when lust hath conceived, it bringeth forth sin: and sin, when it is finished, bringeth forth death.

> *"It is one of the wiles of Satan to take advantage of our outward condition, in that to plant the battery of his temptations."*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Matthew 4:1-11

> *"After we have been admitted into the communion of God, we must expect to be set upon by Satan."*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Matthew 4:1-11

Handout blanks (answers)

Jesus was tempted in all points like as we are, yet without **sin**.

Temptation often offers a **shortcut** to something good.

Teaching point 2: Answer temptation with God's word (7 min)

Each time, Jesus answered, "It is written." He did not argue or rely on his feelings; he stood on Scripture. When the devil quoted Scripture too (Psalm 91), Jesus answered with Scripture rightly understood. Putting God to the test by deliberately jumping into danger is presumption, not faith.

Supporting verses

Matthew 4:4-7: But he answered and said, It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God. Then the devil taketh him up into the holy city, and setteth him on a pinnacle of the temple, And saith unto him, If thou be the Son of God, cast thyself down: for it is written, He shall give his angels charge concerning thee: and in their hands they shall bear thee up, lest at any time thou dash thy foot against a stone. Jesus said unto him, It is written again, Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God.

Psalm 119:11: Thy word have I hid in mine heart, that I might not sin against thee.

Ephesians 6:17: And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God:

> *"In reply to this artful temptation, Christ answered by a quotation from the Old Testament."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Matthew 4:4

> *"To expose myself to any danger naturally destructive, with the vain presumption that God will protect and defend me from the ruinous consequences of my imprudent conduct, is to tempt God."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 4:7

Handout blanks (answers)

Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every **word** that proceedeth out of the mouth of God.

Jesus answered each temptation with, "It is **written**."

Teaching point 3: Worship God alone, and resist (7 min)

The last temptation was the boldest: all the kingdoms of the world in exchange for one act of worship. Jesus' answer was final: "Get thee hence, Satan." When we refuse to divide our worship, the tempter loses his hold. The devil left, and angels came and ministered to Jesus. God does not leave his people alone in the fight.

Supporting verses

Matthew 4:8-11: Again, the devil taketh him up into an exceeding high mountain, and sheweth him all the kingdoms of the world, and the glory of them; And saith unto him, All these things will I give thee, if thou wilt fall down and worship me. Then saith Jesus unto him, Get thee hence, Satan: for it is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve. Then the devil leaveth him, and, behold, angels came and ministered unto him.

James 4:7: Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you.

1 Corinthians 10:13: There hath no temptation taken you but such as is common to man: but God is faithful, who will not suffer you to be tempted above that ye are able; but will with the temptation also make a way to escape, that ye may be able to bear it.

> *"Since the tempter has now thrown off the mask, and stands forth in his true character"*
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Matthew 4:10

Handout blanks (answers)

Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou **serve**.

Resist the devil, and he will **flee** from you.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think the devil began with "If thou be the Son of God"?

To plant doubt about Jesus' identity and the Father's word spoken at his baptism. Temptation often starts by questioning what God has said about us.

2. How did the devil misuse Scripture, and how do we guard against that?

He quoted Psalm 91 out of context to justify presumption. We guard against it by knowing the whole of Scripture and letting Scripture interpret Scripture.

3. What "shortcuts" are we tempted to take today to get good things in wrong ways?

Answers will vary: dishonesty at work, compromise in relationships, cutting corners on commitments.

4. How does knowing that Jesus was tempted help you when you are tempted?

He understands, he sympathizes, and he gives grace and a way of escape (Hebrews 4:15-16; 1 Corinthians 10:13).

Application (3 min)

Identify one temptation you face regularly. Find one verse of Scripture that speaks directly to it, write it down and memorize it this week. When the temptation comes, say the verse aloud and pray for strength.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord Jesus, you were tempted in every way as we are, yet without sin. When we are tired, hungry or alone, keep us from taking shortcuts. Fill our hearts with your word, so that we can answer temptation with "It is written." Help us worship and serve God alone, and give us your strength to stand. Amen.

Sources quoted

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Matthew 4:1-11

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Matthew 4:4

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 4:7

David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Matthew 4:10

Every quotation was checked word for word against the library text it cites. All sources are in the public domain.